

ANTARCTICA



WITH THE SOUTH POLE at its heart, Antarctica is the world's windiest, coldest, and most southerly continent. The last region on Earth to be explored, this huge landmass is not divided into countries, but seven countries claimed territories there. In 1959, however, the Antarctic Treaty suspended those claims and stated that the continent is to be used for peaceful purposes only. Antarctica's sole inhabitants are visiting scientists, working in research stations.

Physical features

Antarctica is almost entirely covered by a vast sheet of ice, in places 4.8 km (3 miles) deep. It contains 90 per cent of the Earth's ice, and 80 per cent of the world's fresh water. The vast Ronne and Ross ice shelves are formed where the ice sheet extends over the ocean.

ANTARCTICA FACTS

AREA	13,900,000 sq km (5,366,790 sq miles)
POPULATION	4,000 international researchers
NUMBER OF COUNTRIES	None
HIGHEST POINT	Vinson Massif, 5,140 m (16,863 ft)
AVERAGE THICKNESS OF ICE CAP	2,450 m (8,000 ft)



Icebergs

Currents beneath Antarctica's vast ice shelves cause giant slabs of ice to break away, the largest of which may be 200 km (124 miles) long. As these enormous icebergs drift north they slowly break up and melt. Only the top third of an iceberg shows above the water.



Mount Erebus

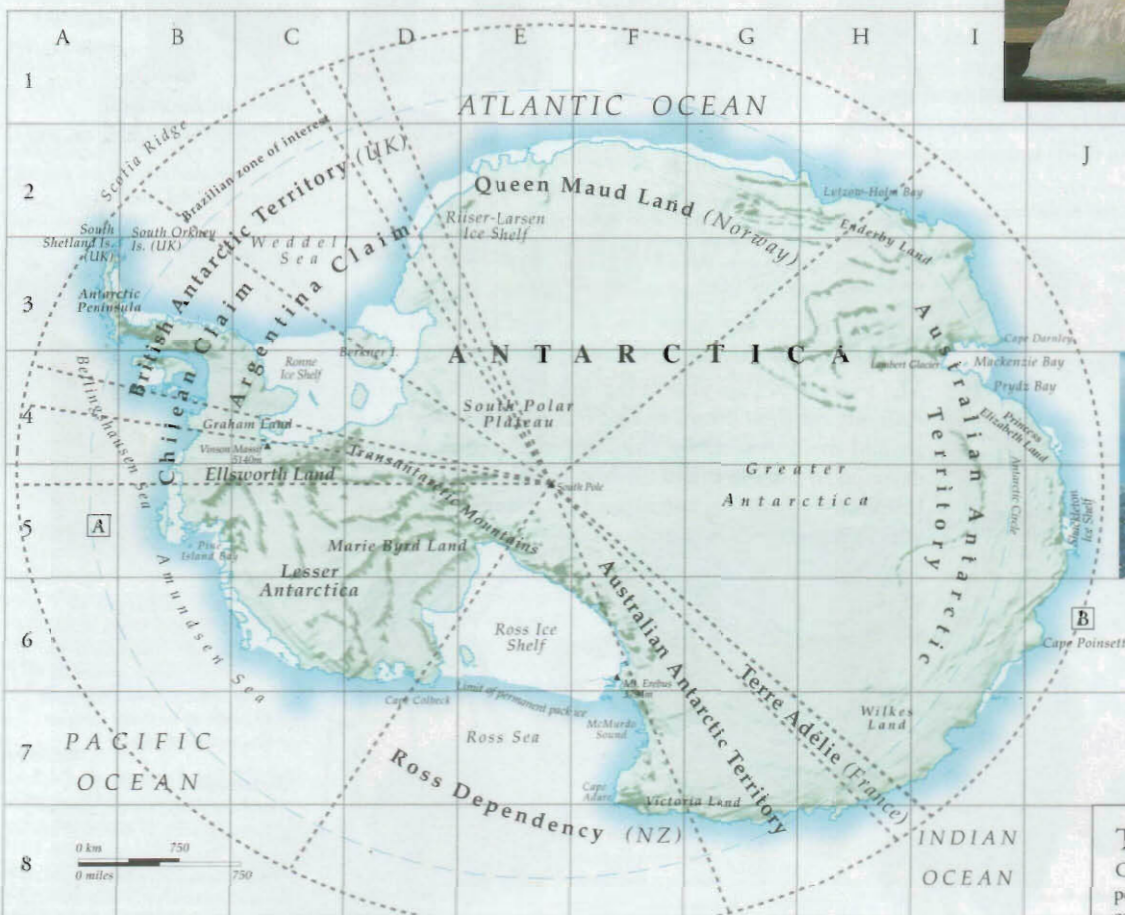
Antarctica has volcanic areas. An active volcano, Mount Erebus, lies on Ross Island on the edge of the Ross Ice Shelf. It forms part of the Transantarctic mountain chain that includes peaks up to 4,570 m (15,000 ft) high.

Tourism

Cruise ships bring around 9,000 people each year to see Antarctica's coastline and wildlife. A hotel now exists on King George Island. Tourists who venture on to the ice must wear insulated clothing and goggles to protect their eyes from the glare.

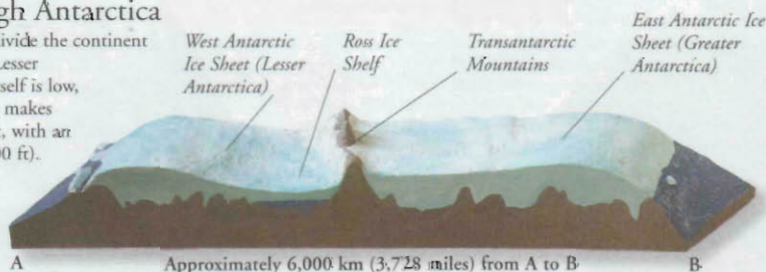


Tourists shelter in a whale skull



Cross-section through Antarctica

The Transantarctic mountains divide the continent of Antarctica into Greater and Lesser Antarctica. Although the land itself is low, the depth of the ice on top of it makes Antarctica the highest continent, with an average height of 2,100 m (6,900 ft). The ice-cap was formed by the build up of snow over the last 100,000 years and contains 90 per cent of the world's ice.



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